

ATLANTA NORTH VESPERS

Demas and the Drift

When Good Work Replaces First Love

2 Timothy 4:10

FACILITATOR ANCHOR — KEEP THIS IN VIEW ALL EVENING

*"Demas did not stop **working**.
He stopped **loving** *rightly*."*

Everything tonight builds toward that sentence. Everything after it flows from it.

Right now, what gets most of your daily attention?

A Christ and devotional life

B Career and professional growth

C Relationships and family

D Personal goals and self-development

"Which of these could slowly replace Christ

—

without you even noticing?"

D o n ' t a n s w e r c o u t l o u d . J u s t s i t w i t h i t .

SCRIPTURE

The Three Mentions of Demas

The arc is the whole point.

COLOSSIANS 4:14

“Luke the beloved physician, and Demas,
greet you.”

”

The co-laborer. Present. Trusted. Named.

PHILEMON 1:24

“Marcus, Aristarchus, *Demas*, Lucas,
my fellow labourers.”

Still in the inner circle. Still working.

2 TIMOTHY 4:10

“For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved
this present world.”

”

Paul doesn't say Demas became wicked. He says Demas loved something else more.

PAIRS DISCUSSION — 2 MINUTES

Did Demas fall suddenly — or drift gradually?

"What do you think happened between Colossians and 2 Timothy?"

Turn to one person near you. Two minutes. Then we share back.

*"This was not an acute collapse.
This was a **chronic condition** of the soul."*

What do you think is the primary diagnosis for Demas?

A Burnout and spiritual exhaustion

B Gradual distraction by success

C Loss of devotional discipline

D Misplaced love — loving a good thing too much

ELLEN WHITE · TESTIMONIES FOR THE CHURCH, VOL. 5, P. 161

"Many are so absorbed in business that they have no time for prayer, no time for the study of the Bible... The cares of this life crowd out the things of eternity."

— Ellen G. White

THE CORE TENSION

Good Work vs. First Love

Both truths are real. The tension is the point.

HOLD BOTH OF THESE AT THE SAME TIME

God calls us to meaningful work in
the world.

The world can quietly replace God
in our hearts.

The tension between the two is not a contradiction. It is the permanent condition of the Christian professional life.

ELLEN WHITE • THE GREAT CONTROVERSY, P. 508

“Satan works to distort the character of God — often making Him seem harsh or unloving — to distract humans, breaking their focus and preventing a close, personal relationship with Him.”

— Ellen G. White

SMALL GROUPS — 3 TO 4 PEOPLE — 4 MINUTES

Two questions for your group:

"How do you know when your work is still worship — and when it has become replacement?"

"What does loving Christ practically look like in a busy professional life?"

*"If the final crisis is about **worship and allegiance** —
not activity — then Demas is not a cautionary tale
about slacking off.*

*He is a cautionary tale about
what we **worship** while we work."*

ELLEN WHITE • STEPS TO CHRIST, P. 44

“It is not so much the fear of punishment, or the hope of everlasting reward, that leads the disciples of Christ to follow Him. They behold the Saviour's matchless love... and to them duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure.”

— Ellen G. White

BIBLICAL REORIENTATION

Christ at the Center

Two texts. Let them breathe.

MATTHEW 6:21

“For where your treasure is,
there will your *heart* be also.”

The heart follows what you value. The treasure reveals what you love.

REVELATION 2:4 — TO THE CHURCH AT EPHESUS

“Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee,
because thou hast *left thy first love.*”

A church that worked harder than any other. But the heart had moved.

ELLEN WHITE • THE ACTS OF THE APOSTLES, P. 547

"The church of Ephesus had let slip her first love. She was more intent on carrying on the forms and ceremonies of religion than on possessing its spirit. She was more anxious to win the approval of men than to win the approval of God."

— Ellen G. White

"The Sabbath is God's built-in resistance against becoming Demas."

Not a rule. A rescue.

THE SABBATH AS CORRECTIVE

It interrupts. It recenters.

Not a rule. A rescue.

IT INTERRUPTS

- Identity through achievement
- Constant striving
- Replacement of God by good things

IT RECENTERS

- Relationship over performance
- Trust over productivity
- Devotion over deliverables

*"Demas kept working.
He lost the Sabbath of the soul first."*

QR PULSE #3 — OPEN RESPONSE

"What is competing with Christ for
your deepest affection right now?"

Scan and respond - your answers are anonymous - word cloud displays live

AFTER THE WORD CLOUD

“I think what we're seeing here...
is that we are all **closer to Demas**
than we thought.”

PRIVATE REFLECTION — 2 MINUTES — NOT FOR SHARING

*"What would it look like to choose Christ
first this week? Not in general. **This week.**"*

On your phone or a piece of paper - answer this for yourself and God only.

B e f o r e w e c l o s e - a q u e s t i o n t o c a r r y h o m e :

**"If someone wrote one sentence about your
spiritual life five years from now — would
it sound more like Colossians... or 2
Timothy?"**

Colossians 4:14 — co-laborer, present, trusted

2 Timothy 4:10 - having loved this present world

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**Close in prayer. Not for success. Not for productivity. For reordered
love.**

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